Organiser, pointed out that, in 2000, when TV penetration first deepened, the Sangh began introducing ‘more games to attract the youth’. It even started inter-shakha (branch) cricket matches to woo younger recruits.[8] RSS leaders at the time were worried that annual growth rates of shakhas were stagnating at about 15 per cent, and so the Sangh announced a major expansion programme. Then RSS leader Ram Madhav announced in 2001 that the organisation had reached ‘30-40 per cent of the revenue blocks in the country’. Its aim was to ‘reach 100 per cent by the year 2006, the birth centenary year of Guruji Golwalkar’.[9]

By 2003, the organisation had about 4,000 full-time pracharaks, but the ‘base from which to draw them’ was still decreasing. A senior RSS paracharak told the journalist Manini Chatterjee that the Sangh was suffering from ‘the three Ts: television, tuitions and technology’. This crisis was existential because its primary recruiting ground had always been students: it had shishu shakhas (six–ten years), bala shakhas (ten–thirteen years), kishore shakha (fourteen–twenty-one years), tarun shakhas (twenty-one–forty-five years) and praudh shakhas (those above forty-five years).[10] Its most prominent leaders, like Vajpayee and Advani, had all been drawn to the Sangh before they were teenagers.[11]

Yet, despite the dip in recruitment, by 2003, the RSS was already what Chatterjee called the ‘biggest NGO in India’, with 45,960 daily shakha meetings. Assuming a base number of fifteen members on average in each shakha, this was close to seven lakh men and boys. At the time, the RSS was also conducting an additional 7,923 Saptahik Milans (weekly meetings) and 7,200 monthly Mandalis (gatherings).[12]

By 2019, the number of daily shakhas had gone up by 28 per cent to 59,266 per year, Saptahik Milans by 117 per cent to 17,229 and monthly Mandalis by 13 per cent to 8,302.

While the RSS does not officially publish data on its primary membership, it does document the daily, weekly and monthly meetings and training camp numbers in its annual reports. I have made an informed estimate of active RSS members from these